Chapter Fourteen

Turning Crimson At Premier’s

~

I

It was a fellow writer, Achal Prabhala, who called to tell me that Premier Bookshop was closing down. ‘Mr Shanbhag seems quite determined,’ said Achal: ‘The landlord is giving trouble again. He has to undergo an eye operation himself. And his daughter is keen that he come visit her in Australia. The nice thing is that he seems very calm about it.’

I claim a long connection with Mr T.S. Shanbhag and Premier Bookshop, but Achal’s connection was deeper. Since he is some fifteen years younger, he had known them all his life. (I was already a teenager by the time I made my first acquaintance with bookseller and bookshop.) Like me and countless other residents of Bangalore, he had come to regard them as indispensable and immovable. When, after many years overseas, Achal had moved back to his home town, it was in the knowledge that Mr Shanbhag and Premier’s would take care of at least one part, perhaps the most critical part, of his life. To see the shop close and the owner retire was for him as unanticipated, and as hard to bear, as the death of a revered family elder.

One of the attractions of Premier’s was its closeness to the café known as Parade’s to the old Bangalorean, but as ‘Koshy’s’ to the new immigrant. Premier’s and Parade’s were a cricket pitch’s distance away from one another. In between lay Variety News, where one could buy magazines in all the languages of the Eighth Schedule (and then some). The usual drill was to start at the bookshop, proceed to the newsagent, and end in the café,